Printer offline or jobs stuck in the queue

Article KB0010075 | Owner: Desktop Support | Subcategory: Printer | Applies to: Windows 11 23H2/24H2 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), MacBook Pro/Air running macOS 14 or 15, Any printer accessed via the PaperCut secure-print system (print server print.acme.example)

Summary

This article guides users and service-desk agents through troubleshooting a printer that appears offline or has jobs stuck in the print queue. It covers common symptoms, likely causes, quick self-help steps, and the formal desktop-support procedure for clearing the spooler, re-adding the printer, and verifying supplies.

Symptoms

- Printer listed as "Offline" in Settings?->?Bluetooth & devices?->?Printers & scanners or in the Print Management console.
- Print jobs remain in the queue with status "Printing", "Error - Printer offline", or "Document failed to print".
- Attempting to print results in no output and the job does not progress.
- Printer properties show a grayed-out icon or a warning triangle.

Common causes

- Print Spooler service stopped or crashed.
- Corrupted or outdated printer driver on the workstation.
- Loss of network connectivity to the print server (print.acme.example) or to the printer itself.
- Printer out of toner, paper, or experiencing a hardware fault (e.g., jam).
- PaperCut hold/release rules preventing jobs from releasing.

Preliminary Checks

Before diving into fixes, verify a few basic items that often resolve the issue quickly. Confirm that the printer is powered on, has paper loaded, and shows adequate toner/ink levels via its control panel or the PaperCut web interface. Ensure the laptop is connected to the ACME-Corp Wi-Fi (802.1X) or wired network; a missing machine certificate will cause the printer to appear offline. Finally, ask nearby colleagues whether they can print to the same device - if multiple users are affected, the problem is likely server- or printer-side rather than isolated to your workstation.

Self-Help Procedure (User)

Follow these steps to clear the local print queue and restart the spooler. If the printer remains offline after completing the procedure, note any error messages and contact the IT Service Desk via the self-service portal, phone extension 4357, or the Teams "IT Help" channel.

1. Open the Start menu, type "Services", and press Enter.
Locate **Print Spooler** in the list.
Right-click **Print Spooler** and select **Restart**. Wait for the service to show a status of "Running".
2. If the Restart option is greyed out, first select **Stop**, wait a few seconds, then choose **Start**.
3. After the spooler restarts, open **Settings -> Bluetooth & devices -> Printers & scanners** (or Control Panel -> Devices and Printers).
Select the problematic printer and click **Open print queue**.
4. In the print queue window, choose **Printer -> Cancel All Documents** to purge any stuck jobs.
Confirm the action when prompted.
5. With the queue cleared, try printing a test page:
Right-click the printer -> **Printer properties** -> **Print Test Page**.
If the test page prints successfully, the issue is resolved.
6. If the test page fails or the printer still shows as Offline, proceed to re-add the printer via the print server (see the Service Desk Procedure below) or contact the Service Desk for further assistance.

Service Desk Procedure (Desktop Support)

When a user reports a printer offline or stuck jobs and the self-help steps have not resolved the issue, follow this

structured process. The goal is to verify server-side health, reinstall the printer connection, and check consumables before escalating to specialized teams.

1. Ask the user for the exact printer name (as shown in PaperCut) and location, and confirm whether the issue affects a single user or multiple users.
If multiple users are affected, skip to step 4 to inspect the print server and printer hardware directly.
2. Guide the user through the self-help spooler restart and queue clear (steps 1-5 above) while you remain on the call or chat to confirm completion.
3. If the problem persists, remotely connect to the user's machine (via Intune or Remote Assistance) and:
- Verify that the printer port points to **print.acme.example**.
- Check the driver version; if it is outdated, download the latest driver from the manufacturer's website and install it.
- Ensure the **Print Spooler** service is set to Automatic and is running.
4. Next, examine the print server:
- Log onto **print.acme.example** with an admin account.
- Open **Print Management** and locate the problematic printer.
- Confirm the printer status is "Ready" and that the port is correct (IP address or hostname).
- Restart the spooler service on the server if needed.
- Review the printer queue on the server for any stuck jobs and purge them.
5. Check the physical printer:
- Confirm it is online, has sufficient toner/ink, paper loaded, and no jams.
- If consumables are low, create a Facilities work order for toner replacement.
- If the printer displays a hardware error, follow the manufacturer's troubleshooting guide or log a hardware ticket with the vendor.
6. Finally, have the user print a test page again. If successful, close the ticket with a resolution note detailing the actions taken (spooler restart, driver reinstall, server queue clear, toner replacement, etc.).

Verification

After completing either the self-help or service-desk steps, verify that printing works reliably. Ask the user to print a typical document (e.g., a one-page PDF) and confirm it emerges without errors. Check the printer status in both the client's Printers & scanners view and the PaperCut web interface to ensure it shows "Online" and "Ready". If the test prints succeed and the queue remains clear, the incident can be considered resolved.

When to escalate

If the printer remains offline after verifying server health, reinstalling the driver, and confirming consumables are adequate, escalate to the **Printing & Scanning / Printer** specialist within Desktop Support. Provide the following details: printer name and location, print server name (print.acme.example), any error codes from the printer's control panel, results of the spooler restart and queue clear, driver version attempted, and toner/paper status. If the issue points to a network-certificate or VPN problem (e.g., machine certificate missing for 802.1X), involve the **Network Support** team. For suspected security-related printing blocks (e.g., Conditional Access policies), alert the **Security Operations** team.

Keywords: printer offline, print jobs stuck, print queue, spooler, PaperCut, print.acme.example, cannot add printer, blank pages, toner low, printer error, restart spooler, re-add printer, print test page